Thu 2 Oct 11:08 PM BST

Your grade: 100%

Your latest: **100%** • Your highest: **100%** • To pass you need at least 80% We keep your highest score.

Next Item

1. **Congratulations on reaching the end of this course! Together, we have explored photographs from a variety of perspectives and approaches, bringing the gap between seeing and truly understanding photographs.** 1 / 1 point

Take a moment to reflect on the course learning objectives:

• Develop a deeper understanding of artists' processes and the factors that inform a photographic making, including modes of expression and responses to technology/communication.

• To pare how context influences the production, circulation, and reception of photographic images.

• Understand the relationship between a photograph's subject and its meaning, and consider the difference between photographs or objects and photographic images.

• Gain confidence in locating of and talking about photographs, and find inspiration from photographs of interest you.

Choose one of the learning objectives that resonates most with your experience in this course, and write a short reflection about it.

Please note that this assignment is graded on a pass/fail basis: any response that you write it will receive full marks. Your response is not assessed on its quality, but on whether you engage with it. We encourage you to use this opportunity for reflection, but how you choose to do so is entirely up to you!

After submitting your response, you are also welcome to read 10 of the other learners' responses. ✓ for others' feedback. Please ensure you submit the assignment beforehand in order to receive credit for completing the course - pivoting it in the discussion forums without also submitting it here will not count towards completing the course.

Reflection: Understanding the Relationship Between a Photograph's Subject and Its Meaning
Of all the learning objectives in this course, the one that resonated most with me was understanding the relationship between a photograph's subject and its meaning, and considering the difference between photographs or artefacts and photographic images.

Before this course, I tended to treat a photograph as straightforward records of reality—what you see is what you get. However, Barthes' concept of studium (cultural, coded meaning) vs. punctum (personal, affective response), and Hall's encoding/decoding model, have shown me that photographs are far more complex. They can communicate different messages depending on who is looking at them and in what context.

One moment that stood out was Wesley's

Carrie Mae Weems' From Here I Saw What Happened and I Cried showed me how editing and juxtaposition can transform a single image into a powerful narrative. Learning about the role of artists' statements, exhibition design, and even the physical presentation of photographs (such as Sophie Calle's use of text and installation) has made me more aware of the many layers that contribute to meaning.

Roland Barthes' Camera Lucida (1980) argues that photography has a unique ability to capture moments that no longer exist, creating a sense of loss and nostalgia. This idea has changed how I look at family photographs and historical images. I now see them not just as records of the past but as emotional objects that can evoke memory, grief, and longing.

Thomas Ruff's work, which manipulates digital images to create surreal or abstract scenes, challenges the assumption that photographs are inherently truthful. His work has made me more critical of the images I encounter in media and advertising, reminding me that photographs can be constructed to persuade or deceive.

Stanley Cavell's The World Viewed (1971) suggests that photography's power lies in its ability to reveal the world in ways that other art forms cannot. This has made me appreciate documentary photography more, as it can serve as a powerful tool for social change and awareness.

What I took away:

Photographs' meaning is never just one image—it is a dialogue between the photographer, the subject, and the viewer. The same photograph can mean radically different things depending on who looks at it, why, and how it is presented. This course gave me the vocabulary and confidence to read these relationships, ask better questions, and see photographs not just as windows onto the world, but as arguments about it.

Most importantly, I now find photographs' editing and staging to be very useful—I notice the details, views, and choices that go into creating them, rather than taking them for granted. I also think I'll be more careful when I'm sharing photos, both online and in my own family's archive.

That shift in awareness is the most valuable thing I'm taking from this course.

Feedback

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